

When advertising feels like friendship

Edit sheet: what to film, what to generate, and which file goes on each line.
Presenter: Rathan Vijearajah. About 8:34 long.

1. What to film

Shoot these yourself. Tick them off as you go.

☐

The fake commercial

You holding the serum like a real ad: polished beauty lighting, clean background, slow product close-ups (hands, bottle turning). End the take by pushing the bottle right into the lens until it fills the frame.

☐

The casual YouTube version

Same product, same outfit, same hair. Softer light, relaxed, like a creator filming at home. Say: "I've been using this every morning and I genuinely love it."

☐

Talking head

You to camera, reading every line marked "Film: talking head" in the script below. Same setup for all of them.

☐

Split-screen pair

Nothing new to shoot. The split screen reuses the commercial and the YouTube version side by side.

**Monitor push-in**

Slowly push the camera toward a monitor or phone screen until the screen fills the frame. Used for the transition into the YouTube window.

**Reference photos**

Photos of your outfit, hair, the bottle label and the lighting setup, for matching the AI shots.

2· AI shots to generate

Make these in Higgsfield. The prompts are in your production guide on the pages listed.

**Set reveal**

Camera pulls back from the bottle to show the lights, stands and monitor. Use your own still as the start frame (guide p.7).

**Lifestyle montage**

Four 2–4 s clips of a creator: waking up, getting ready, breakfast, airport (guide p.8).

**Sports-drink ad**

A generic, unbranded sports-drink commercial. No real logos.

**Beauty creator**

Year 1 with mild acne, testing products. Year 2 with clearer skin, holding the serum to camera (guide p.9).

**Fitness creator**

Working out, then sitting with a supplement tub talking to camera (guide p.9).

**Young viewer**

Someone in a dim bedroom watching a creator on a laptop (guide p.10).

3 · Script and files

Read top to bottom. Under each line: the file to put on screen, what you film, or which AI shot to use. File names match `motion-graphics/out/`.

■ Graphic file □ Optional graphic ■ You film ■ AI shot

01 Opening — the same product, two different ads

Think about this for a second. If a random person appears in a commercial and tells you to buy a skincare product, you immediately know what's happening. They're selling you something.

B02-AdvertisementLabel-ALPHA.mov

Film Fake commercial: beauty lighting, product hero inserts

Film Bottle pushed into lens to end the shot

But what if it's someone you've been watching online for three years?

AI

Set reveal: pull back from the bottle to show lights, stands and monitor (Higgsfield prompt p.7)

They're doing their morning routine, talking about their skin, maybe showing an old photo of a breakout, and then they say: "I've been using this every morning for the last few weeks, and I genuinely love it."

B01-YouTubeWindow-ALPHA.mov

B25-CommentsPop-ALPHA.mov

Film Casual YouTube version: same product, same wardrobe

That feels different. It doesn't really feel like an ad anymore. It feels more like a recommendation from someone you know.

03-NotAnAd.mp4

optional: use your talking head instead

No voiceover. Graphic only.

B05-SplitLabels-ALPHA.mov

Reuse

Split screen: commercial left, YouTube version right

And that's exactly why influencer marketing is so powerful. Brands aren't just paying influencers for views. They're paying for something much more valuable. Trust.

B06-TrustOnBlack.mp4

Film

Talking head

No voiceover. Graphic only.

B07-TitlePresenter.mp4

02 Why this works

A big part of why this works comes down to something called a parasocial relationship.

B09-TermLowerThird-ALPHA.mov

B08-NameLowerThird-ALPHA.mov

Film

Talking head

Basically, it's a one-sided relationship where you feel like you know someone, even though they don't actually know you.

06-OneWayRelationship.mp4

And social media is almost built for this. You see creators waking up. Getting ready. Eating. Travelling. Talking about their relationships. Showing their homes. Talking about their problems. Sometimes you're watching them every single day.

B10-CalendarFill-ALPHA.mov

AI Lifestyle montage, 2-4 s per clip: morning, get ready, breakfast, travel (prompts p.8)

So after a while, they stop feeling like strangers. They start to feel familiar. And familiarity can turn into trust. That trust is incredibly valuable to advertisers.

B11-ExposureFamiliarityTrust.mp4

B12-EvidenceCard1.mp4

03 Traditional ads vs. influencer ads

Think about how different that is from a normal commercial. If you see a celebrity holding a drink in a commercial, you understand the arrangement. They got paid. They're in an ad. Everyone knows what's happening.

Film Talking head

AI Generic drink commercial B-roll, unbranded

Influencer advertising can be way more subtle. You could be watching someone's morning routine. They show their coffee. Their outfit. Their skincare. And somewhere in the middle they say: "By the way, I've actually been using this serum for the past few weeks."

Reuse Or reuse the casual YouTube version

AI Beauty creator morning routine: coffee, outfit, skincare

Now the ad is sitting inside normal content. It doesn't interrupt the video. It becomes part of the video. And that changes how we experience it.

10-AdInsideContent.mp4

04 Where it starts to get uncomfortable

That's where things start getting a little uncomfortable. Because from a marketing perspective, this is extremely smart. The influencer has already spent months or years building the audience. They've built familiarity. They've built credibility. They've built a personality people connect with.

11-BuiltOverYears.mp4

optional: use your talking head instead

So when a company pays them to promote something, that company gets to borrow all of that trust. They're not starting from zero. They're entering a relationship that already exists.

12-BorrowedTrust.mp4

And the language usually doesn't sound like advertising either. It sounds like: "You guys keep asking me about this." Or: "I've genuinely been obsessed with this." Or: "I would never recommend something I don't actually use." That language matters. Because it feels personal.

13-AdLanguage.mp4

optional: use your talking head instead

05 What the research is trying to answer

When I started looking into the research, I didn't just want to know whether influencer marketing works. We already know brands use it because it works.

Film

Talking head

I wanted to understand why people trust influencers so much, whether that trust affects buying decisions, and whether simply putting "sponsored" or "ad" on a post really solves the problem.

14-ResearchQuestions.mp4

So I focused on research around parasocial relationships, credibility, sponsored content, and purchase intention.

B26-SearchTerms.mp4

optional: use your talking head instead

And one of the biggest patterns that comes up is that influencers become more persuasive when audiences see them as relatable, authentic, or trustworthy.

B13-EvidenceCard2.mp4

Which makes sense. You're probably going to take a recommendation more seriously from someone you feel connected to than from a random corporate ad. The interesting part is that the relationship itself starts becoming part of the marketing.

Film

Talking head

06 Beauty influencers

Take beauty influencers. Imagine you've watched the same creator for two years. You've seen their skin when it was bad. You've seen them try different products. You've seen what worked and what didn't.

AI

Beauty creator, year 1: mild acne, testing products (prompt p.9)

Then one day they show you a serum and say: "This is honestly what changed my skin."

AI

Same creator, year 2: clearer skin, holds the serum to camera

That statement has history behind it. You're not just evaluating the serum. You're evaluating it through everything you already know about that person.

17-BeautyTimeline.mp4

That makes the recommendation more powerful. The same product shown in a normal commercial doesn't have that relationship attached to it.

Reuse

Callback: reuse the fake commercial from the opening

07 Fitness influencers

The same thing happens in fitness. Maybe you follow someone because you like their workouts. You've watched their transformation. You trust some of their advice. Then eventually they recommend a supplement.

AI

Fitness creator: workout, then seated with the supplement (prompt p.9)

Now you're not looking at that supplement completely objectively. Your opinion of the creator comes with it. If you trust them, some of that trust transfers to the product.

18-TrustTransfer.mp4

Then maybe there's a discount code. A link in the bio. A limited-time offer. And suddenly the whole thing becomes really easy.

B18-CheckoutFlow.mp4

optional: use your talking head instead

Watch. Trust. Click. Buy.

20-WatchTrustClickBuy.mp4

08 What brands are really buying

And that's why brands love influencer marketing. They're not just buying reach. They're buying access to an audience that already has a relationship with the person delivering the message. That is incredibly valuable.

B19-BrandFlow.mp4

Because a brand might take years to build trust with a customer. An influencer might already have it.

22-YearsVsAlready.mp4

optional: use your talking head instead

So instead of saying: "Trust our company." The brand is basically saying: "Trust this person you already like." That's a much stronger sales tool.

23-TrustSwap.mp4

09 But what about #ad?

But then there's the obvious question. What about sponsorship disclosure? Influencers are supposed to tell people when something is sponsored. You'll see: "Paid partnership." "Sponsored." "Ad."

B17-DisclosureZoom.mp4

24-DisclosureLabels.mp4

And that definitely matters. People should know when money is involved. But I don't think that completely fixes the issue. Because knowing something is sponsored doesn't suddenly erase the relationship.

Film Talking head

If you've trusted someone for three years, seeing the word "ad" probably doesn't make all of that disappear.

B20-ThreeYearsOneSecond.mp4

You might actually think: "Yeah, they're getting paid, but they wouldn't recommend something they didn't believe in."

Q7-YouThinking.mp4 optional: use your talking head instead

And that's exactly the point. The disclosure tells you there's a business relationship. But the influencer's credibility is still doing most of the selling.

B14-EvidenceCard3.mp4

10 The counterargument

Now, influencer marketing isn't automatically bad. There are real benefits. Small businesses can reach very specific audiences. Creators can make money from their content. People can discover products they genuinely like. And some creators are very selective about who they work with.

26-Benefits.mp4 optional: use your talking head instead

AI Optional stock/AI: small shop, creator editing

So the issue isn't simply: Influencers get paid, therefore influencer marketing is bad. That's too simple.

27-TooSimple.mp4 optional: use your talking head instead

The bigger issue is what happens when the creator's relationship with the audience becomes something that can basically be rented by a brand. That's where the line gets blurry.

B21-RentListing.mp4

11 Why younger audiences matter

And this becomes even more important with younger audiences. If someone grows up watching YouTubers, TikTok creators, or streamers every day, those creators can feel very different from traditional celebrities.

B22-DayMonthYear-ALPHA.mov

AI Viewer in a dim bedroom watching a creator on a laptop (prompt p.10)

They talk directly to the camera. They respond to comments. They share personal stories. You might feel like you grew up with them.

29-GrewUp.mp4 optional: use your talking head instead

So when they recommend something, it can be harder to separate: “I trust this person” from “I trust this product.” Those are not necessarily the same thing. But influencer marketing can make them feel like they are.

B23-PersonProductMorph.mp4

12 Conclusion — what is really being sold?

So what’s really being sold here? Obviously the product. But not just the product. Attention is being sold. Access is being sold. Credibility is being sold. And most importantly, trust is being sold.

B27-FinalStackOverlay-ALPHA.mov

Reuse Return to the opening: commercial and YouTube frame

That’s what makes influencer marketing different from a traditional ad. The creator has already built the relationship. The brand gets to step into it.

Film Talking head

And once advertising starts feeling like friendship, we probably need to be more critical about what we're actually watching.

Film Talking head, slow push-in

Because sometimes the most valuable thing in the entire deal isn't the product being promoted. It's the trust that already existed before the ad ever started.

32-Ending.mp4

Files ending in -ALPHA.mov are overlays: put them on the track above your footage in Premiere.